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Kinship and marriage among the Nuer

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The rules about eating and nakedness apply, though in a lesser degree, to kinsfolk of the wife of her parents' generation as well as to the parents themselves, for all her kinsfolk are her husband's in-laws. A man will not appear naked or eat in the homes of his wife's paternal and maternal uncles and aunts or appear naked before the wives of his wife's close kinsmen. I have seen a man's wife's paternal aunt make a great fuss when unintentionally he appeared naked before her. He knelt behind another man to hide his nakedness and receive her reproaches when he became aware of his misdemeanour. On another occasion the fuss was made by a bride's paternal uncle's wife while the astonished bridegroom hastily retired into a hut. Unintentional affronts of this kind are quieted by small payments, such as a spear or a goat. As the genealogical distance from the wife increases, the obligation on the part of her husband to observe these rules lessens. It altogether ceases when the wife's father and maternal uncle have paid beasts to enable him to eat in their homes. Should a divorce take place, the son-in-law at once ceases to treat his in-laws with respect.

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The wife's brother and her other kinsmen of his generation are not avoided, but her eldest brother may refrain from eating with the bridegroom before a child has been born. Nuer say, 'the wife's brother is your brother; since he gave you his sister he became your brother', and 'the husband of your sister is your brother because he will get a cow (the *yang waca*) on the marriage of your daughter'. After the birth of children a man and his wife's brother can, if great friends, jokingly curse one another in obscene language. The wife's brother's wife is highly respected till a child has been born, though not to the same extent as the mother-in-law, unless the mother-in-law is dead; then 'she becomes your mother-in-law and must be respected as deeply as a mother-in-

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law'. Nuer say that she then becomes your real mother-in-law and that '*ca mandong*', 'she has become a grandmother' (to the children of her husband's sister, who call their maternal uncle's wife 'grandmother'). The only in-law whom a man need not at any time treat with reserve is his wife's sister. He can joke with her and even exchange abusive language with her. However, if his mother-in-law  102 is dead he treats her eldest daughter with reserve, for she has then taken her mother's place: 'she has placed the food on the fire' (at her mother's mortuary ceremony). A man and his wife's sister's husband, whom he calls *warombaida*, may be on intimate terms.

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